

AP Psychology: The Complete Exam Guide

All 5 units explained, the Article Analysis and Evidence-Based questions, a research-methods playbook, and 10 hard practice questions.

Hi, I'm **Pigo!** I'll drop tips all through this guide.

**2:40**

hours total
90 + 70 minutes

75+2

multiple-choice +
free-response questions

5 units

biology to
mental health

71-74%

scored 3 or higher
in recent years

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01 THE EXAM AT A GLANCE

Two sections, one score

Your AP score (1–5) is weighted towards multiple choice (about two-thirds), with two free-response questions making up the other third. Both test applying concepts and evaluating research.

67%

Section I · Multiple choice · 75 questions

33%

Section II · Free response · 2 questions

Exam structure

Section	Weight & timing	What you do
I · Multiple choice	≈67% of score 1 hr 30 min 75 questions	Apply concepts and theories to scenarios, evaluate research methods and study designs, and interpret data from tables and graphs.
II · Free response	≈33% of score 1 hr 10 min 2 questions	Article Analysis Question (AAQ): analyze a summary of a research study. Evidence-Based Question (EBQ): build an argument using three provided sources.

FULLY DIGITAL

Everything happens in Bluebook

You answer every question, including the written responses, in College Board's **Bluebook** testing app. Responses are submitted automatically at the end. Practice typing timed answers before May.

SCIENCE PRACTICES

Research methods run through everything

Expect questions on **variables, sampling, operational definitions, statistics and ethics** in every unit, not just a single research chapter.

How to use this guide

Just starting?

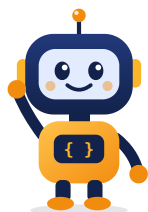
Read pages 2–6, then follow the roadmap on page 8 month by month.

Mid-year?

Check the traps on page 7 and drill the free-response playbook on page 6.

Exam in weeks?

Take the 10 questions on page 9 in 13 minutes, then use the final-four-weeks plan.



Pigo's tip: Psychology questions reward **application**. For every term, practice inventing a short real-life scenario that shows it.

SECTION I

02 The multiple-choice section

75 questions in 90 minutes gives you 1 minute 12 seconds per question.
Most questions are short scenarios asking which concept applies.

75

questions, many
scenario-based

1:12

minutes per question on
average

67%

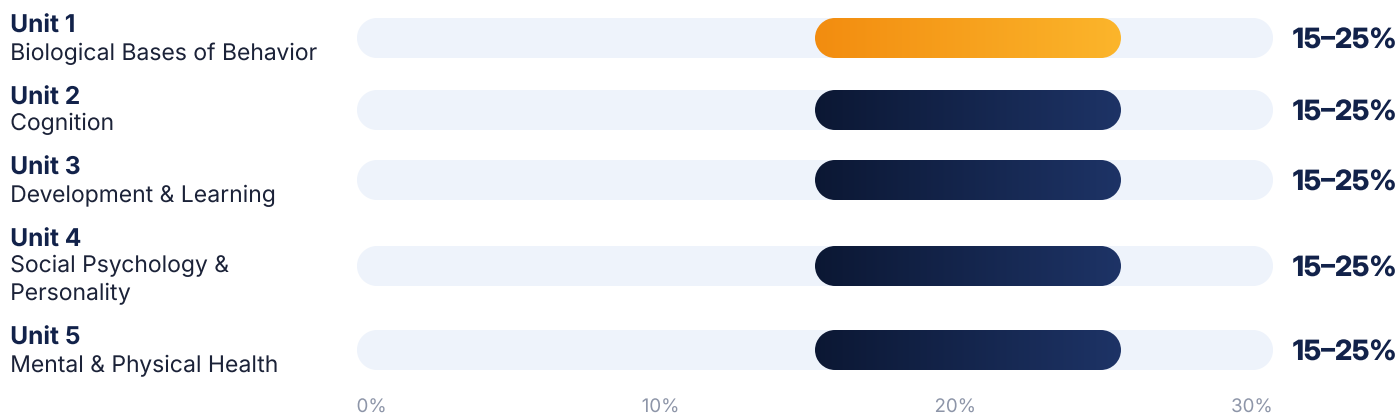
of your total AP score

0

points lost for a wrong
answer, so never leave
one blank

How the questions are weighted by unit

College Board gives a range for each unit's share of the exam. Bars show minimum to maximum.

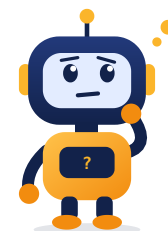


What this means for your study time: The five units carry the same range, so balance your review. Research methods are tested inside every unit.

Strategies that work on this section

- Find the **key detail** in the scenario that points to one concept, then match it.
- Separate look-alike terms:** negative reinforcement vs punishment; proactive vs retroactive interference.
- Identify the research design:** experiment (random assignment) or correlation (no manipulation).
- Read graphs for the variables** before reading the question.
- Eliminate distractors** that are real terms but don't fit the scenario.
- Move on at 90 seconds** and return to flagged questions.

Correlation $\neq$ causation. Only an experiment with **random assignment** supports cause and effect.



03 WHAT THE COURSE COVERS

The 5 units, in plain English

Everything on the exam fits into these five units.

UNIT

1

15–25%

Biological Bases of Behavior

The brain, nervous system, sleep and senses.

Be ready to: explain neurons and neurotransmitters; brain regions and plasticity; the endocrine system; sleep stages and disorders; sensation and sensory thresholds.

UNIT

2

15–25%

Cognition

Perception, memory, thinking and intelligence.

Be ready to: explain perception and attention; memory encoding, storage and retrieval; forgetting; problem-solving, heuristics and biases; intelligence and testing.

UNIT

3

15–25%

Development & Learning

How people grow and learn.

Be ready to: describe physical, cognitive and social development (Piaget, Erikson); attachment; classical and operant conditioning; observational learning.

UNIT

4

15–25%

Social Psychology & Personality

How people affect each other, and who we are.

Be ready to: explain attribution, conformity, obedience and group behavior; prejudice; personality perspectives and assessment; motivation and emotion.

UNIT

5

15–25%

Mental & Physical Health

Stress, disorders and treatment.

Be ready to: explain stress and coping; positive psychology; DSM categories of disorders; biological and psychological treatments and their evidence.

◆ Research methods: tested in every unit

Variables

Independent, dependent and confounding variables; operational definitions.

Sampling

Random sampling vs random assignment; generalizability.

Statistics

Mean, median, SD, correlation coefficients, statistical significance.

Ethics

Informed consent, deception, debriefing, confidentiality.

SECTION II

04 The 2 free-response questions

70 minutes for 2 questions. Both are based on sources, so they test how you use evidence, not just definitions.

AAQ • 7 pts

EBQ • 7 pts

Each question is worth 7 points

AAQ

Article Analysis Question

~25 minutes • 7 points

Read a summary of a research study. Identify the research method, variables, operational definitions, statistics and ethics, then explain whether the findings can be generalized.

Use the exact numbers and terms from the article in your answers.

EBQ

Evidence-Based Question

~45 minutes • 7 points

Read three sources. Make a claim in response to a prompt, support it with evidence from at least two sources, and explain how each piece of evidence connects to a psychological concept.

Cite sources by number, and explain the concept, don't just quote.

♦ A time plan for the 70 minutes

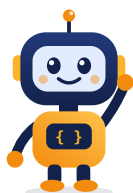
Read
article
5 min

Write AAQ
~20 min

Read sources
10 min

Write EBQ
~35 min

A suggested split, not a rule. Start with the question type you're strongest at, and never leave a question blank.



In the EBQ, every piece of evidence needs an **explanation** that links it to a named psychological concept.

05 FREE-RESPONSE PLAYBOOK

Anatomy of a full-credit answer

Here is an AAQ-style study summary with full-credit answers, and the habits that earn points.

PRACTICE TASK • WRITTEN BY ACT SAT GO

Practice prompt (AAQ style): Researchers randomly assigned 120 college students to sleep either 4 or 8 hours for one night. The next morning, participants completed a 20-word recall test. The 8-hour group recalled a mean of 14.2 words (SD 2.1); the 4-hour group recalled 9.8 (SD 2.6). The difference was statistically significant ($p < .01$). (a) Identify the research method. (b) Identify the operational definition of memory. (c) Explain whether the results can be generalized to older adults.

Full-credit response

- ① (a) An experiment, because participants were randomly assigned to sleep conditions and the researchers manipulated sleep.
- ② (b) Memory was operationally defined as the number of words correctly recalled from a 20-word list the next morning.
- ③ (c) No. The sample included only college students.
- ④ Older adults sleep differently and may experience age-related memory changes, so they might not respond to sleep loss in the same way.

- ① **Name the method** and give the evidence for it.
- ② **Operational definition** = exactly how the variable was measured.
- ③ **Answer the question directly** (yes or no) first.
- ④ **Explain using the sample** and a relevant difference.

◆ Five habits for every free-response question

- 1** Answer each part separately and in order.
- 2** Use the study's exact numbers and terms.
- 3** Name the psychological concept in every explanation.
- 4** In the EBQ, cite at least two different sources.
- 5** Stuck? Define the concept accurately and apply it.

06 LEARN FROM OTHERS

10 traps that cost points

Meet **Glitch**. He lives in these ten mistakes. Squash each one before May.

Negative reinforcement is **punishment!** (It isn't.)



01 Negative reinforcement vs punishment

Negative reinforcement removes something unpleasant to **increase** a behavior; punishment decreases a behavior.

02 Random sampling vs random assignment

Random sampling helps generalize to a population; random assignment allows cause-and-effect conclusions.

03 Correlation as causation

A correlation shows a relationship, not that one variable causes the other.

04 Negative correlation as "weak"

$r = -0.85$ is a strong correlation. The sign shows direction, not strength.

05 Proactive vs retroactive interference

Proactive: old information disrupts new.
Retroactive: new information disrupts old.

06 Sensation vs perception

Sensation detects stimuli; perception organizes and interprets them.

07 Classical vs operant conditioning

Classical pairs stimuli (involuntary responses); operant uses consequences (voluntary behavior).

08 Validity vs reliability

Reliability is consistency; validity is measuring what a test claims to measure.

09 Definitions instead of application

Free-response answers need the concept applied to the specific scenario.

10 Ignoring the sources in the EBQ

Evidence must come from the provided sources, cited and explained.

Quick self-check: a student studies more to avoid a parent's nagging, and the nagging stops. Is this negative reinforcement or punishment? (Negative reinforcement: removing nagging increases studying.)

07

PLAN YOUR YEAR

Your study roadmap to May

A steady plan beats a last-minute rush. Shift the months to match your teacher's pacing, and practice research-method questions every week.



Sep – Oct

Biology



Unit 1 + research methods

Neurons, the brain, sleep and senses. Learn the research-methods vocabulary early.

Nov – Dec

Thinking



Unit 2

Perception, memory, thinking and intelligence. Start AAQ practice with short study summaries.

Jan – Feb

Growth



Unit 3

Development and learning theories. Practice applying conditioning terms to scenarios.

Mar – Apr

People + health



Units 4–5

Social psychology, personality, disorders and treatment. Write timed EBQs.

Early May

Sharpen



Full timed sections

Full 75-question sets and both free-response types under timing.

Exam day

May



AP Psychology exam

Sleep well, charge your device, and use the checklist at the end of this guide.

• The final four weeks

Week	Focus	Target
4 weeks out	Diagnose: 38 multiple-choice questions plus one AAQ	List your two weakest units
3 weeks out	Drill look-alike terms and research methods	80%+ on unit drills
2 weeks out	Full practice exam under timing	Finish both sections on time
Final week	Light review: vocabulary, research methods, traps	Rest the night before

08 TEST YOURSELF

10 practice questions

Original questions written by ACT SAT GO in the style of the exam, pitched at the harder end. Give yourself **13 minutes** for all ten, then check page 10.

1 RESEARCH METHODS

A study finds $r = -0.72$ between hours of social media use and sleep quality. Which conclusion is justified?

- A Social media use causes poor sleep
- B There is a weak relationship because r is negative
- C There is a strong negative relationship between the two variables
- D Poor sleep causes people to use social media

2 UNIT 1 · NEUROTRANSMITTERS

A drug blocks the reuptake of serotonin. What is its most likely effect?

- A Less serotonin remains in the synapse
- B More serotonin remains active in the synapse
- C Serotonin receptors are destroyed
- D Neurons stop producing action potentials

3 UNIT 1 · BRAIN

After a stroke, a patient understands speech but struggles to produce fluent sentences. Which area was most likely damaged?

- A Wernicke's area
- B The occipital lobe
- C The cerebellum
- D Broca's area

4 UNIT 2 · MEMORY

After learning a new phone number, Mia keeps dialing her old one by mistake. This is an example of:

- A proactive interference
- B retroactive interference
- C the serial position effect
- D source amnesia

5 UNIT 2 · THINKING

After seeing news reports about plane crashes, Leo overestimates how dangerous flying is. This illustrates:

- A the representativeness heuristic
- B functional fixedness
- C the availability heuristic
- D confirmation bias

6 UNIT 3 · CONDITIONING

A driver buckles her seat belt to stop an annoying beeping sound. Buckling up is maintained by:

- A positive reinforcement
- B positive punishment
- C extinction
- D negative reinforcement

7 UNIT 3 · DEVELOPMENT

A child understands that a tall, thin glass and a short, wide glass can hold the same amount of water. According to Piaget, the child has mastered:

- A object permanence
- B conservation
- C egocentrism
- D abstract reasoning

8 UNIT 4 · SOCIAL PSYCHOLOGY

Seeing a classmate trip, Sam thinks "he's so clumsy," but when Sam trips he blames the wet floor. This shows:

- A the actor-observer bias
- B the mere-exposure effect
- C groupthink
- D social facilitation

9 UNIT 4 · CONFORMITY

Which change would most likely **reduce** conformity in Asch-style line-judgment studies?

- A Increasing the group size from 3 to 6
- B Making the task more ambiguous
- C Having participants answer aloud
- D Having one other group member give the correct answer

10 UNIT 5 · TREATMENT

Which treatment approach focuses on changing distorted thought patterns, such as "I always fail"?

- A Psychoanalysis
- B Systematic desensitization alone
- C Cognitive-behavioral therapy
- D Electroconvulsive therapy

09

CHECK YOUR WORK

Answer key & explanations

Read every explanation, even for questions you got right. Each one points to a pattern that keeps coming back on the exam.

#	Answer	Why
1	C	$r = -0.72$ shows a strong negative correlation. Correlations don't establish causation in either direction.
2	B	Reuptake inhibitors (such as SSRIs) keep serotonin in the synapse longer, increasing its effect.
3	D	Broca's area controls speech production; damage causes halting, effortful speech with good comprehension (Broca's aphasia).
4	A	Proactive interference: older learning (the old number) disrupts recall of newer learning.
5	C	The availability heuristic judges likelihood by how easily examples come to mind, and vivid news makes crashes easy to recall.
6	D	Removing an unpleasant stimulus (the beeping) increases the behavior: negative reinforcement.
7	B	Conservation, the understanding that quantity stays the same despite changes in shape, marks the concrete operational stage.
8	A	The actor-observer bias attributes others' behavior to disposition and our own to the situation.
9	D	Asch found that a single dissenter who gave the correct answer sharply reduced conformity.
10	C	Cognitive-behavioral therapy targets and restructures distorted thoughts and the behaviors linked to them.

9–10

Strong. Move on to full timed free-response practice.

6–8

On track. Revisit the unit behind every miss on page 4.

0–5

Build foundations now. Drill look-alike terms and research-methods vocabulary first.

10 KNOW THE TARGET

How students score

In recent years, about 71–74% of students earned a 3 or higher on AP Psychology, and about 14–15% earned a 5. Steady preparation is what moves a score up a full point.

71–74%

of students earned a 3 or higher in recent years

14–15%

earned the top score of 5 in recent years

3+

is the score many colleges accept for credit or placement

What each AP score means

5

Extremely well qualified

4

Very well qualified

3

Qualified

2

Possibly qualified

1

No recommendation

Ranges reflect recent College Board score distributions and shift a little each year. Credit and placement policies vary by college, so check each college's AP policy.

Exam-day checklist

- ☐ **Bluebook** is installed and updated, and your device passed the exam check
- ☐ Device **fully charged**, with the charger packed
- ☐ Admission ticket and photo ID, as your school requires
- ☐ Confirm your **exam day and start time** in May with your AP coordinator
- ☐ Plan your time: about **70 s** per multiple-choice question; **~25 min** for the AAQ and **~45 min** for the EBQ
- ☐ Answer **every** multiple-choice question. Wrong answers don't lose points
- ☐ Review **research-methods vocabulary** the night before
- ☐ Practice citing sources by number in the EBQ

In the free-response section: use exact terms and numbers from the study, apply each concept to the scenario, cite at least two sources in the EBQ, and explain how every piece of evidence supports your claim.



ACT SAT GO • 1-ON-1 AP TUTORING

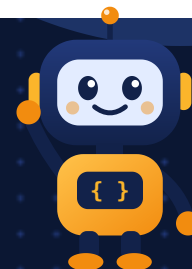
Aiming for a 5? Get a personal AP Psych plan.

Book a free diagnostic lesson. We'll find your weakest units, review your practice responses, and give you a week-by-week plan to exam day in May.

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Concept tutoring

Live 1-on-1 sessions on all five units, with scenario-application drills.

Free-response coaching

Practice AAQs and EBQs and get feedback against rubric-style criteria.

Timed exam practice

Full-length multiple-choice sets with score reports, so you see progress before May.

◆ Contact us

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